A VIBE CODER'S GUIDE

Docker: do you actually need it?

Your AI tool says “install Docker”. Here is when to listen.

Don’t miss the one-question rule

SWIPE ››



01 / 08

The pain

Your AI coding tool says “install Docker” and you have no idea why. Or the app works on your laptop and breaks everywhere else.

> THE GOOD NEWS
>
> **Both have the same fix, and you might not need it.**



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Docker is a lunchbox

A toy brick castle falls apart at a friend's house: different bricks, wobbly table. Pack it in a lunchbox with every brick and its own little table, and it stands up anywhere.

> IN SOFTWARE
>
> **Docker packs your app with everything it needs, so it runs the same on any computer.**



Why your AI asks for it

Your AI tool does not need Docker.

Some of your project's tools do. Supabase runs a full copy of your backend (database, logins, storage) on your laptop using Docker.

> SO
>
> **If Docker is not running, that setup fails, so the AI asks you to install it.**



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A safe practice copy

On the copy, the AI can test, break things and reset without touching your real users or live data.

> THE POINT
>
> **Mistakes happen on the copy. Only finished, tested changes go live.**



The one-question rule

Ask this at the start of every project:

If the AI makes a mistake here, could it damage data I care about?

YOUR ANSWER

Yes: use Docker or a separate test project.

No: keep it simple and skip it.



Use it when you have

A database you will test against (Supabase, Postgres, MySQL, Redis). Several pieces running together (website, API, database). Plans to deploy as a container (Fly.io, Railway, Cloud Run, a VPS).

> MOST OF ALL
>
> **The database is the big one.**



Skip it for

Landing pages and static sites. Frontend-only apps that call hosted APIs. Simple scripts and automations. Quick prototypes. Sites on Vercel or Netlify.

> TIP
>
> **Add it later if the project grows a real database.**



Two honest caveats

Docker Desktop can use a few GB of memory, so quit it when a project does not need it. The local copy starts empty: it is for testing, not a replacement for your real database or hosting.

> REMEMBER
>
> **Docker is a practice space, not your live app.**



One question. Then build.

Building with AI and not sure which side of the line your project sits? Our first conversation is free.

What's the most confusing thing your AI coding tool has asked you to install?